After a few minutes of chitchat, I made my pitch.

Sir Keith listened respectfully, raptor-eyed, but when I'd finished he ummed and aahed.

All sounded very wonderful, he said, but he was semi-retired. Trying to cut back on projects, you know. He wanted to streamline his life, focus on his passions, chiefly sailing. America's Cup, and so forth.

In fact he was scheduled to begin a holiday the very next day.

How to talk to a man who's just hours away from starting a holiday into rolling up his sleeves and taking on an impossible project?

There's no way, I thought.

But the whole point of these games was: Never give up.

So I kept on. I went at him, and at him, and told him about the soldiers I'd met, their stories, and also a bit of mine. One of the first and fullest accounts I'd ever given anyone of my time at war.

Slowly I could see that my passion, my enthusiasm, were making dents in Sir Keith's defenses.

Brow furrowed, he said: *Well…Who have you got so far on this project?*

I looked at Elf. Elf looked at me.

That's the beauty of it, Sir Keith. You see…you're the first.

He chuckled. *Clever.*

No, no, really. You can get the band back together, if you wish. Hire anyone you want.

Despite the overt and obvious salesmanship, there was a great deal of truth in what I was saying. We hadn't yet managed to trick anyone else into joining us, so he'd have carte blanche. He could organize a staff however he wished, bring on every single person who'd helped him pull off such a successful Olympics.

He nodded. *When are you thinking of doing this?*

September.

What?

September.

You mean ten months from now?

Yes.